STATUS REPORT

Guinea-Bissau: status report

Edition of 2026-10-12 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Guinea-Bissau acquired its first plan for the digital estate as a single thing on 28 March 2025, when Decreto n.º 10/2025 approved the Estratégia Nacional para a Transformação Digital (ENTD.GW) 2025–2030 as an integral annex, comprising six strategic objectives, ten pillars and 55 interventions, prepared by UNU-EGOV under a UNDP contract. Its ten pillars run from infrastructure and data through literacy and trust to public services, and each intervention is indexed to an objective with a duration in months and suggested start and end dates. Its authors chose a five-year horizon deliberately so as not to be limited to the current legislature. The strategy was launched at a ceremony presided over by the Prime Minister on 29 January 2025, two months before the decree that approved it.

Two instruments have followed it. The Council of Ministers approved a National Digital Skills Policy by decree on 19 May 2026, confirmed in July among three approved instruments, with no implementation plan or budget line published, and a project document setting the strategy's implementation priorities, governance and resources was presented by UNU-EGOV to a government delegation on 9 September 2026, with no adoption date.

What it replaced was very little. The ITU recorded no adopted national broadband policy or plan for Guinea-Bissau in 2019, while Cabo Verde, Guinea, Senegal, the Gambia, Mali and Angola all carried one in the same edition. The European Union's Multiannual Indicative Programme 2021–2027 set three priority areas — human development, a green and inclusive economy, and good governance and stability — and digital is not among them; digital skills appear only as part of the skills to be built through vocational training for jobs and the green economy.

The constraint the documents themselves name is discontinuity. The Ministry of Public Health records that the preceding national health development plan for 2018–2023 was never formally approved, and that the non-approval compromised implementation of the IANDA Guiné Saúde project. The education ministry's sector plan counts sixteen changes of executive power in the four decades to 2017, at an average tenure of 2.5 years, and says that instability weakened the public administration, education included; the government's Beijing+30 report names recurrent political instability, which breaks the continuity of public policy, among the persistent challenges to programmes for women's and girls' rights. Guinea-Bissau scored 40.9 of 100 for Overall Governance in 2023, 44th of 54 African states, its Foundations for Economic Opportunity category falling 2.1 points over 2014–2023 to 28.5, the only one of the four to deteriorate.

Legislation and regulation

Guinea-Bissau's first horizontal electronic-transactions statute was still a draft in May 2026, the ICT regulator ARN having put a Projeto de Lei das Transações Eletrónicas out to public consultation with responses closing on 28 May 2026. The 112-article bill would settle the legal effect and evidential value of data messages, the formation of electronic contracts, the licensing of trust-service providers, signatures and time stamps, consumer protection and the limits of intermediary liability. Even enacted it would not commence: entry into force is left to a date the responsible Minister designates, possibly provision by provision.

The operative regime remains Lei n.º 5/2010, the Lei de Base das Tecnologias de Informação e Comunicação, which sets the rules for establishing and operating ICT networks and services and constitutes the ARN as the body regulating, supervising and sanctioning them. Four regulations made under it were published together in September 2010, covering interconnection, supervision and sanctions, public consultation and the offer of networks and services, and they give the regulator a ladder from fines through restriction and suspension to revocation.

Adoption, not drafting, is where instruments stall. Decreto n.º 6/2018 gave the 1998 Lei da Terra its general regulation twenty years late, the decree's own preamble blaming political-military imperatives and constant governmental instability. A draft access-to-information bill was validated in April 2024 and had gone no further by October that year. The Council of Ministers approved, with amendments, a draft Electronic Communications Law at a session chaired by the transitional president, Horta Inta-a, and the transitional legislature passed a Digital Integrity Law on false information online in May 2026. The same council ratified the African Union, Budapest and United Nations cybercrime conventions that month, the last of which Guinea-Bissau had signed in October 2025.

Four gaps sit in the digital statute book at once — no access-to-information law, no electronic-transactions law, no domestically effective data-protection regime and no cybercrime or cybersecurity statute, three cybercrime conventions ratified notwithstanding — and in each case a text exists while the last step of adoption, promulgation or gazette publication has not been taken.

Data protection

Guinea-Bissau had no dedicated data protection law and no data protection authority in September 2026, the matter being handled sectorally by several institutions; a draft law would create a Data Protection Agency and leave its organisation to decree.

Both obligations have been owed for sixteen years, binding the country since the ECOWAS Supplementary Act was adopted in February 2010, and neither has been met.

The Act is precise about what is missing. Article 2 requires a legal framework protecting the privacy of data in its collection, processing, transmission, storage and use; Article 14 requires an independent administrative authority, with Articles 16 and 17 securing its members' immunity, freedom from instruction and incompatibility with government office. Article 3(3) applies the Act to any processing carried out in a UEMOA or an ECOWAS member state, so Guinea-Bissau falls inside its scope on either footing, and Article 36 lets personal data leave the Community only after the controller informs the national authority — a duty with nobody to perform it to. UNECA reads the regional signature as not legally binding for as long as the Act remains unpublished in the country's official gazette.

The constitutional floor is general rather than digital. Artigo 44.º(1) recognises rights to personal identity, good name, image and the reserve of the intimacy of private and family life, Artigo 48.º(1) makes the home, correspondence and other private communications inviolable save as criminal-procedure law expressly provides, and Artigo 42.º(6) voids all evidence obtained by abusive intrusion into private life, the home, correspondence or telecommunications. But the text carries no article on informática or automated data processing in its title on fundamental rights and duties.

What is on offer is sectoral. The draft electronic transactions bill would impose a privacy duty at article 95 requiring every collector, processor or controller to observe accountability, lawful processing, data minimisation, retention limits, security and protection by design, with a breach that causes harm to another punishable by a fine of up to 2,000 monetary points of 100 FCFA each, five years' imprisonment or both.

Regional collaboration

Regional recognition of Bissau-Guinean identity documents runs ahead of the domestic registry beneath it: Guinea-Bissau is one of six ECOWAS states to have fully operationalised the ECOWAS National Biometric Identity Card for cross-border movement, and in March 2026 262 women cross-border traders received ECOWAS biometric cards in Cacheu under a Guinea-Bissau–Senegal mobility project.

The bloc's binding digital instrument is not in force. ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 on Personal Data Protection was adopted in Abuja on 16 February 2010 as an Act of the Authority, and Article 48 annexes it to the ECOWAS Treaty as an integral part — but the same article makes entry into force conditional on publication in both the Community's Official Journal and each member state's Official Gazette, where Article 47 has national publication follow thirty days after the Commission's notification. Newer regional work sits at the same stage: a Draft Directive Governing Electronic Communications in West Africa, begun in 2019, reached a validation workshop in September 2025 that was to build consensus for its ministerial approval, and the ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024–2029 was adopted by ministers at Cotonou on 4 October 2024. A technical committee to implement the ECOWAS free-roaming regulation was created in Guinea-Bissau in 2021, chaired by ARN-TIC.

None of it is financed from the centre. The ECOWAS Community budget for 2026–2028 carries no disaggregated digital or ICT appropriation anywhere in its expenditure structure; its only ICT-named line ran at nil from 2024 through the 2028 estimates, against total estimated 2026 income of UA 411,724,082. The whole agenda now sits in one portfolio, Amin Amidu Sulemani taking Infrastructure, Energy and Digitalisation as General Birame Diop assumed the Commission presidency on 31 August 2026.

The UEMOA transposition chain is slow. The Ministry of Finance describes the treasury single account as an innovation of the harmonised public-finance framework whose domestic hook is article 29 of Lei n.º 2/2015, transposing Directive nº 06/2009/CM/UEMOA.

Sixteen years separate that directive from the national regulation that makes the account operable, the obligation entering the statute book in 2015 and acquiring its implementing regulation only in March 2025.

Standards

Guinea-Bissau takes no part in setting the standards it is expected to meet: ISO's member record for the country shows no technical-committee liaisons of any class. The national standards body itself is the DSNPQ, a directorate of service inside the Ministère du Commerce, Industrie, Tourisme et Artisanat rather than an autonomous national standards institute — standard-setting housed in the ministry that promotes the trade being standardised. The WTO Secretariat found that the expansion of the country's foreign trade is hindered by the lack of operational quality control mechanisms, a diagnosis of 2017 that nothing since has displaced.

For digital standards the reference document is the government interoperability framework produced under the World Bank-financed WARDIP programme, a consultancy deliverable that the government approved as a national regulation in August 2026, with no entry-into-force date published. It names four critical success factors — process identification, standards compliance, IT-systems collaboration and the institution of a legal framework, so the framework itself names a missing legal layer as a condition of its own success, and it names the country's political

instability and the organic uncertainty across successive governments as the reason it needs a formal governance structure, proposing a central authority with an oversight committee or advisory council including the private sector and civil society.

The trust standards that would make electronic documents travel are still being worked out regionally. In March 2024 an online ECOWAS expert workshop with the EU's D4D Hub discussed priorities for a regional electronic signature certification policy and formulated guidelines, with a roadmap still to be defined. Guinea-Bissau's regulator works the lusophone circuit alongside the West African one, recording in 2021 the 13th General Assembly of ARCTEL-CPLP, the 10th meeting of Portuguese-language communications authorities and engagement with the ITU.

Domestically the regulator has stated the market's shape: ARN finds that both operators hold significant market power and warns that Telecel's residual share of investment could seriously compromise competition (June 2025).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Online space narrowed sharply with the November 2025 takeover: the coup leaders ordered radio stations off air and blocked four major social platforms nationwide from 27 November 2025, and a law against false information online followed in May 2026.

The one part of Guinea-Bissau's administration with a prescriptive duty to consult is its telecoms regulator, and the channels outside that sector have been narrowing while it has held. Decreto n.º 15/2010 makes general public consultation obligatory before eleven named categories of regulatory decision — among them defining relevant markets and declaring significant market power, imposing or removing obligations on operators, limiting frequency use-rights, setting quality-of-service parameters, consumer-protection measures, number portability, universal-service obligations and the terms of specific offers for users with disabilities. The mechanics are prescribed too: prior notice in the national press or on the ARN website, the consultation document available at the regulator's seat for at least 15 working days, responses running for no fewer than 20 working days and accepted by any written means, responses published save for identified confidential material, and a final document recording the ARN's global appreciation of every response received — with interested parties defined expressly more widely than those holding a legally protected interest. Urgent measures are excluded, on the cumulative conditions that the measure be immediate, proportionate and provisional.

The route is used. ARN ran a public consultation on the wholesale and retail telecoms cost model in 2021, alongside follow-up work on submarine-cable implementation and on short emergency numbers, and the draft Electronic Transactions Law was put to public consultation in 2026.

Outside that sector the channel is narrower. There is still no access-to-information statute, and what government publishes of its own accord has improved over the decade to 2023 while what a citizen can actually obtain has moved the other way. Media freedom fell 5.1 points over 2014–2023 to 53.7 of 100 in 2023, 29th of 54, and rural representation and participation was among the country's most deteriorated measures over the same period.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Guinea-Bissau's treasury carries 3.0 per cent of the digital lines in the 2026 budget as appropriated, XOF 25 million of XOF 821.5 million, against 17.6 per cent of XOF 966.5 million in the 2025 budget as proposed; the grant lines are the same in both years, and the fall is on the domestic side.

The 2026 budget gives the head of government's digital transformation project, which covers accounting software, a government data centre and communications, XOF 10 million of domestic money, a revenue and expenditure platform at the territorial administration ministry XOF 5 million, and the WARDIP connectivity programme XOF 10 million of counterpart beside XOF 454.6 million of grant. The 2025 proposal had put XOF 20 million of domestic money into the same transformation project, XOF 60 million into a data platform for the public investment programme and XOF 50 million into an e-health project. The education management information system, at XOF 140 million, and a health digitalisation project named for Sightsavers, at XOF 201.9 million, are carried by grant with no domestic counterpart (2026), as in 2025. Execution against the 2026 budget had been reported only in-year, to the second quarter (2026).

The largest external commitment came with a US$0.5 million government counterpart and runs to 2028. The backbone it finances was put out to international tender in March 2026 as a public-private partnership to design, build, operate and maintain it. Own-source money for connectivity runs through the regulator: a draft strategic plan for the Universal Access and Service Fund, prepared for ARN in November 2025, records that the fund received new resources from an increase in the levy on operators' revenues.

Identity is carried by a vendor rather than the budget: Semlex financed the national biometric document production centre in Bissau and the equipment in the regions (2021), under a contract the Ministry of Justice renewed that year.

MoUs and other agreements

The one agreement on record that bears on the digital estate is fiscal: the IMF completed the eleventh review of its Extended Credit Facility programme in June 2026, naming the revenue administration platform and a taxpayer census among the reform actions. No memorandum of understanding specific to the digital sector had been recorded as at September 2026.

New investments

Guinea-Bissau's digital financing rests on one World Bank operation. An IDA grant of SDR 45.7 million, US$60.0 million equivalent, is the country's national allocation under the Western Africa Regional Digital Integration Program SOP1, a US$266 million concessional programme approved in November 2023 and running to 2028 shared with The Gambia, Guinea and Mauritania, covering broadband, digital economy governance and digital public services.

Beside it sits risk cover rather than money: MIGA holds an active political-risk guarantee of US$25.4 million over Sonatel SA's equity investment in Orange Bissau (2025), running to 2029 as one tranche of a EUR 433.7 million Orange programme across Guinea and Guinea-Bissau.

The rest is smaller and mostly regional. UNDP's Mais Digit@l for Guinea-Bissau, run with the Ministry of Digital Economy, covers 2025 to 2030. Guinea-Bissau is one of six West African countries in the African Development Bank's Strengthening Tax Administration Capacity Project, launched in August 2026 on an African Development Fund grant, and one of seven in the Bank's Strengthening Health Systems and Medical Regulations project, in the pipeline for 2026 to 2030.

Two systems now running were paid for elsewhere: the customs platform deployed with UNCTAD's technical assistance was funded by the African Development Bank (January 2026), and the technical assistance behind the IMF's enhanced data dissemination standard came from the Government of Japan (July 2024).

Six commitments bear on Guinea-Bissau as at September 2026 — five distinct operations, the World Bank's appearing twice — starting between 2023 and 2026 and ending out to 2030; three name the country as recipient, three are regional. Four of the six are grants, one a concessional loan to the region and one a guarantee, with no

equity investment and no commercial borrowing. Connectivity takes three of them and about US$85 million of the roughly US$88 million attributable to the country as at September 2026, the rest going to skills, health information systems and tax administration. The World Bank leads by a wide margin at US$60.0 million as at September 2026, ahead of MIGA's US$25.4 million and UNDP's roughly US$3 million; the African Development Bank appears only through regional grants shared across several countries.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Guinea-Bissau's mobile market went backwards through the first half of 2025: effective mobile stations fell to 1,828,708 in the second quarter, down for the third quarter in four from 1,989,605 in the third quarter of 2024, and the shift from 3G to 4G reversed, 3G users rising 9% to 1,031,923 while 4G users fell 2% to 823,110. Internet access subscriptions on 3G and 4G boxes and USB modems fell from 22,295 to 20,456 over the same quarter.

Only two operators work the mobile market — Orange Bissau with 1,290,663 subscribers against Telecel Guiné-Bissau's 538,045 in the second quarter of 2025 — and Orange took 81% of sector turnover and supplied 99% of the quarter's 7,181,811,064 FCFA of sector investment.

There is no national fibre backbone: middle-mile capacity runs mainly on microwave links with an embryonic metropolitan fibre network in Bissau. There is also no internet exchange point, one of 51 countries without one as at 21 August 2026. The backbone designed under WARDIP-GB specifies 2,877 km of cable and 56 nodes, targets more than 99% of the population and is to be run by a private wholesale operator under an exclusive licence. President Umaro Sissoco Embaló launched the programme in Bissau on 2 April 2025.

The regulator's own measurement across the Bijagós and Bolama in May 2023 found a signal present in 81.4% of MTN readings and 73.8% of Orange's, but quality non-existent, very poor or poor in 56.0% and 58.7% of them, and barely half of data tests completed. 4G networks covered 35.8% of the population in 2024 and internet use reached 32.5% of individuals in 2025. The Ibrahim Index scored internet and computers at 11.5 of 100 for 2023, 46th of 54.

Starlink began commercial service on 19 June 2025 at about XOF 228,000 for hardware and about $63 a month, under a provisional general authorisation granted by ARN-TIC in April 2025, which the regulator extended on 14 September 2026 to 31 December 2026, pending a definitive regime. Four Digital Public Squares were given connectivity at Farim, Gabú, Buba and Mansoa during 2025.

Data Storage

A feasibility study assessed what a national government cloud would require and prepared terms of reference and tender documents for it (2025).

The national digital strategy plans a phased Centro Nacional de Dados, beginning at small scale, to end the fragmentation of small processing centres spread across ministries and to serve as a test-bed for private-sector projects — and states that its viability depends on reliable electricity, which the strategy places outside its own scope.

Nothing commercial fills the gap in the meantime. No top-five cloud provider had an established or announced public cloud region anywhere in West Africa (early 2025), and a Tier III colocation data centre positioned to serve the WAEMU bloc broke ground in Abidjan in November 2022. The effect shows in public data: the country's national summary data page is hosted on a national Open Data Platform provided by the African Development Bank.

Energy

Guinea-Bissau's grid has no generation of its own: installed on-grid capacity was 0 MW in 2023, the national grid supplied since 2019 solely by a single rented 34 MW heavy-fuel-oil barge. Peak demand was 25 MW and the generation mix 100% heavy fuel oil (2023), and the regional OMVG interconnection is intended to replace the rented barge.

The utility loses money on every unit it sells. Average cost of service was US$0.42/kWh in 2023 against an average tariff of US$0.38/kWh, with transmission and distribution losses running at 35% and bill collection at 80%. EAGB is the state electricity utility and the Ministry of Energy the sector's policy and regulatory authority.

Supply is a Bissau service. Access ran at 58% in the capital against under 5% across the rest of the country in 2023, and the same year 64.3% of the urban population had electricity against 20.7% of the rural population, a divide of 43.6 percentage points. The absolute deficit was 1.28 million people in 2023, even though the country was among the twenty fastest-electrifying in the world over 2010-23. The Ibrahim Index put access to energy at 16.9 of 100 for 2023, 43rd of 54 and among the country's ten worst indicators.

What has moved has moved off-grid and offshore. An EU-funded 500 kWp solar mini-grid on Bolama became operational in January 2024, and a World Bank project plans a US$8.5 million subcomponent for solar mini-grids connecting 1,200 households on the Bijagós islands and individual solar systems for at least 100 health facilities.

Power is the constraint on digitalisation rather than a background condition of it. UNDP found that the main challenges to the country's e-justice pilots were lack of electricity, connectivity and internet availability. The environmental and social management framework for the WARDIP fibre build, dated April 2023, ties the digital infrastructure programme to energy and water efficiency, climate risk and e-waste.

Technical Capacity

Guinea-Bissau's digital transformation agency, ITMA, carries a mandate the World Bank judged possibly overly ambitious against comparable institutions, and one that overlaps in part with the telecoms regulator ARN's (2023). The government had expressed a commitment to digital skills, but "little has been done to date" (2023). The same assessment rates digital capability across the civil service and political bodies as low, a judgement the measured baseline in the justice sector supports, almost all surveyed staff having never received digital training at work.

The weakness is administrative before it is technical. Public Administration scored 26.7 of 100 in 2023, 50th of 54, having fallen 1.5 points over 2014-2023, with effective administration at 25.8 and 49th of 54.

Individual technical agencies show the same shape. The national meteorological institute has few technical staff with the relevant skills and a low budget for its core activities, its technological infrastructure is not adapted to digitalisation, and it operates no automatic weather stations at all.

Training that does happen is donor-run and small. Civil registry officials were trained on digital registration systems during 2025, and the regulator's technicians took a benchmarking mission to the Nigerian Communications Commission and entered a Sida-backed regional training programme in 2021.

Cybersecurity

Guinea-Bissau was placed in Tier 5, Building, the lowest of the five tiers of the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, for an overall score below 20 of 100. A feasibility study assessed what a national CERT and critical information infrastructure protection would require and prepared terms of reference and tender documents for both (2025).

The statute book is thin. The 2010 ICT framework law sets the ground rules for ICT networks and services and constitutes the regulator, and the country has enacted no Electronic Transactions Act and has no comprehensive legal regime for personal data protection (2024).

Movement since 2025 has been at draft and undertaking stage. On 22 January 2025 the government presented the results of studies on cybersecurity and undertook to create a national cybersecurity and data protection agency, and in July 2025 the Council of Ministers approved a draft National Cybersecurity Strategy alongside a data governance policy and an interoperability regulation. The national digital strategy schedules a repeating public campaign on secure and responsible online behaviour — security, privacy protection and resistance to hate speech and distorted information — from July 2026 and repeated to 2029.

At regional level, ECOWAS ministers adopted a directive on confidence-building measures in the cyber and ICT field in October 2024, urging member states to implement it without delay upon its publication.

DPI

Data Exchange

Guinea-Bissau's interoperability framework became a government instrument in August 2026, when the government approved a national interoperability regulation, announced by the WARDIP programme with no decree number or entry-into-force date. The design behind it is the eGIF-GW version 2.0 of 31 July 2024, produced under the World Bank-financed WARDIP programme. Its design runs over legal, organisational, semantic and technical layers and specifies GovStack building blocks, PKI with digital signature and an eID, and it names ITMA as coordinator and as responsible for the framework's design. It also names the institution of a legal framework as one of four critical success factors, and justifies its own governance design by the political instability and organic uncertainty its authors say characterise successive governments.

Underneath the design there is no exchange layer. Government digital platforms are mostly siloed (2023), a diagnosis the state makes of itself in strategic objective OE3 of the national digital transformation strategy, which finds platforms built in silos at different maturity levels with no capacity to interoperate. A UNDP project aims at progressive integration of the country's identification systems, starting from the digitisation of the civil registry, and SIREC is framed as the foundation for future interoperability with the ID card, the voter register, social protection and the courts rather than as a live one.

What exchange happens is bilateral. When a company is formalised at the CFE its details pass electronically to the tax authority, which validates them and issues the taxpayer number without a separate application. The reformulated Sistema Integrado de Informação Criminal, inaugurated in March 2023 under the West African Police Information System programme to exchange information between police and investigation agencies, runs at the Polícia Judiciária and is to extend to the Guarda Nacional, the Polícia de Ordem Pública and the migration services, in a state with no data-protection statute and no appointed authority. Customs went live on ASYCUDAWorld on 26 January 2026, with interfaces to external national systems built into the deployment. A draft regulation on the interoperability of public and private digital systems was approved in Council of Ministers in July 2025, alongside draft data-governance and cybersecurity texts.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Guinea-Bissau's national identity system runs on other people's money and a private vendor's production line: it depends on UNDP and Swiss Confederation funding and on Semlex under a revenue-sharing arrangement, with no dedicated domestic budget line identified, and the World Bank rates progress on biometric ID as slow and at risk. The Ministry of Justice runs civil identification through its Directorate General of Civil Identification, and an 18th card-production centre opened at Safim in January 2026.

The national digital transformation strategy provides for a technical and legal framework for digital identity with a matching authentication platform, which it calls an essential tool for every process of digital transformation, and sets a 24-month window from July 2026 to June 2028 to build them, framed within a foundational identity system and tied to the digitisation of the civil registry. Lei n.º 11/2013 makes voter registration permanent, single and compulsory and issues a voter card, manual or biometric, against it.

The Bilhete de Identidade is mandatory from age 15 and requires a birth certificate, so no credential is issued at birth or in early childhood, and a 2025 World Bank operation carries a prior action on ECOWAS-compliant biometric identity cards, under which the government planned a campaign to issue them free to all civil servants and pensioners. Guinea-Bissau is one of six ECOWAS states to have fully operationalised the regional biometric identity card for cross-border movement and trade, even though it is not among the countries financed under the World Bank's WURI identity programme and the ECOWAS Commission handles its part in the programme through its Directorate of Free Movement of Persons and Migration.

About 46 per cent of children under five had their birth registered (2025). Civil registration scored 25.0 of 100 in 2023, 50th of 54, having fallen 12.5 points over the decade. Mobile justice and civil registration services reached remote communities during 2025 through Candonga di Justiça, and a registry officer on one mission called for identity cards to be issued on the islands themselves to spare islanders long trips.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Every institution authorised on the regional instant-payment scheme in Guinea-Bissau is a bank: no mobile-money operator appears in the country's column, where Benin's participants include Moov Money and MTN and Burkina Faso's include Orange Money. Five participants were authorised as at 31 July 2026 — Banco da África Ocidental, BDU, Coris Bank, Ecobank and Orabank — the joint-smallest national cohort in the Union alongside Niger, against 24 in Senegal and 23 in Côte d'Ivoire out of 104 Union-wide. The scheme went live across all eight WAEMU states on 30 September 2025, and Orange and MTN both provide mobile money in the country, each in partnership with a bank (2022) — they are outside the rail, not absent from the market. One structure is licensed as a payment institution in Guinea-Bissau on the central bank's register, out of thirty-one across the Union.

That single licence is the joint-smallest payment-institution sector in the monetary union, level with Niger's and set against eleven in Senegal, nine in Côte d'Ivoire and three in Togo.

The rules are made in Dakar. Règlement n° 15/2002/CM/UEMOA sets the Union-wide framework for payment systems, Instruction n° 001-01-2024 is the standing text for supplying payment services and binds banks, payment institutions, microfinance and e-money institutions alike, and oversight of the infrastructures and of payment means is exercised by the BCEAO itself. The central bank also operates the plumbing — SICA-UEMOA for retail clearing and STAR-UEMOA for real-time gross settlement, backed by a guarantee fund and intra-day advances — with the national Treasury sitting as a settlement participant alongside the commercial banks. Presenting the national ID card, ECOWAS card or passport is a legal requirement for opening a bank account.

Government money moved first. The Ministries of Finance and Public Administration launched a blockchain platform in May 2024 that monitors in real time the disbursement of public salaries and pensions by commercial banks, running eligibility, budgeting, approval and disbursement on a tamper-evident ledger that raises alerts on inconsistent salary information; the public wage bill fell from 84% of tax revenues in 2020 to 50% by October 2024, against a WAEMU convergence criterion of 35%. A Treasury Single Account regulation approved in March 2025 opens the account in the books of the BCEAO and requires all public funds, including project money, to be deposited into it. Tax can be paid from a phone through the banking system or the mobile operators, without an account or a prior declaration.

Retail is another matter. Access to banking services scored 4.3 of 100 in 2023, 47th of 54 and the country's second-worst indicator of the 96 measured, against a population of which close to 43 per cent remained outside the formal financial system (2021); fewer than one respondent in ten to the 2021-22 household survey reported using mobile banking. The fintech sector is small, an estimated 5 to 15 firms, with no standalone national fintech strategy (2026).

Registries

All of Bissau's civil birth registry books have been digitised, with 230,967 records organised, and more than 7,500 registry books covering over 1.3 million civil records across five of the country's regions have been catalogued (2025).

SIREC, the integrated citizen registration and statistics system, went live on 22-23 January 2025 at the 1.ª Conservatória de Bissau, with the first certificate issued through it at the closing event of the EU-funded GESTDOC project. It is designed as a single database for births, acknowledgements of paternity, marriages, deaths and other civil-status acts, with management of a unique identification number for each citizen among its functions, and was built with Camões, Portugal's Instituto dos Registos e do Notariado and the University of Aveiro. A 2025 decree is named as the legal framework for digital civil registration underpinning it.

The registry it digitises is old. Civil registration runs on the Código de Registo Civil approved in 1967 and carried over at independence, which the national vital-statistics yearbook calls old and ill-adapted to the Guinean context, with a draft revision produced by Portuguese Cooperation held at the Ministry of Justice. The network ran from independence to 2009 on one central conservatória, eight regional delegations and 28 posts across 36 sectors, and 42 registry posts had been opened inside hospitals by 2022 under a protocol with the health ministry.

The business register publishes its own throughput: 7,047 companies formalised through the Centro de Formalização de Empresas between May 2011 and April 2025, with women's share of promoters rising from 7.0% in 2012 to 13.9% in 2024. The electoral roll stood at 966,152 registered voters for the November 2025 elections, against 893,618 at the legislative election of 4 June 2023, and was handed to the elections commission unchanged, in paper and electronic form, for the referendum of 30 August 2026; the electoral commission had adopted a biometric voter card for the registration ahead of the 2018 legislative elections. A National Social Registry is being established and expanded under a World Bank project approved in January 2025 and running to 2030; a Social Registry of beneficiaries begun in 2015 held 6,200 individuals in 2,250 families at the end of July 2017.

Land vests in the State under Lei n.º 5/98, private use rights require a written contract and registration at the Conservatória do Registo Predial, and Decreto n.º 6/2018 created the framework for a national land cadastre, its atlas and a Livro de Tombo; a World Bank-funded Geodata and Mining Cadastre System for the natural resources ministry was put out to tender and won by Spatial Dimension in April 2015. The postal addressing format places a four-digit postcode to the left of the locality name (March 2005).

Sectoral management information systems

DHIS2 has carried Guinea-Bissau's national health information — routine programme data, disease surveillance and bednet campaign management — for over a decade, with tracker programmes serving as electronic registries for maternal and child health and for immunisation. Its climate-health tooling sits on a testing instance rather than in national production, three of the four named climate-health use cases are at concept stage pending funding, and a second national dataset runs outside it altogether: UNICEF's WASH programme, in which about 2,500 community health workers enter data on tablets. UNDP reports strengthening the DHIS2 installation and implementing an eLMIS joining service-delivery and supply-chain data, and a national integration and analytics platform is being built for INASA and the health ministry with Global Fund support to consolidate more than twenty fragmented health data systems.

The education system's data rests on a project with an end date. The SIGE is being equipped, trained and technically advised through PESIDE, a project of the NGO FEC with the education ministry running from May 2021 to November 2026, whose activities include implementing the statistical platform in every Regional Directorate of Education, with European Union financing. The project works with 2,097 school directors, 215 inspectors, 11 regional statistical technicians and 16 staff of the central planning office. School inspection has been digitised with World Bank GEMS support, replacing paper forms with collection by inspectors on visits, though the ministry's own statistical yearbook has not been published for years.

SIGDAJ, the justice information and data management system, was built inside the Ministry of Justice and Human Rights by the ministry's own ICT director and tested on paper records from the Buba tribunal, the criminal register and the Centro de Acesso à Justiça, alongside a justice-sector adaptation of DHIS2, where digitising cases directly into it produced real-time statistics in place of counting cases in Microsoft Word (2023). The justice systems UNDP mapped were all central ones: the ministry's SIGDAJ, a prisoners' database, the Judiciary Police's forum website and the access-to-justice centre system (2023).

Five domains have a named management information system — health, education, justice, criminal information and civil registration — and each rests on a donor project, a regional programme or in-house ministry work rather than on an establishing decree or law; the one sector with a founding instrument, land, has no evidence of a running system. The public health institute's yearbook counted 1,747 of 2,073 expected health-centre monthly reports entered for 2022, 82.2%. The platform's developers signed an agreement to support the public health institute in strengthening the national health information system, with new HIV and tuberculosis patient-tracking tools (2026).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Guinea-Bissau's digital-government programme is, so far, a schedule. The national strategy provides for a Portal do Cidadão as a single point of entry to state services in the second half of 2025, with a mobile platform mirroring it in 2026, for a Carta de Serviços Públicos inventorying every state service and the processes behind it between January and September 2025, as the precondition for a re-engineering programme with an annual target for services digitised, and for a whole-of-government SMS notification service in the first half of 2026, under a strategic objective committing the state to prioritarily digital public services and to designing every new service digital-first. Free citizen access to services on the gov.gw domain is to be paid for either by the operators as consideration for their licences or by the Universal Access Fund — a choice the strategy leaves open. Measured against delivery, the country ranked 170th of 193 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, and ITMA, the digital transformation agency, has responsibilities that overlap in part with the telecoms regulator's (2023).

What runs, runs in revenue. Kontaktu is the tax authority's operational portal for declarations and payments, and a December 2025 service instruction makes it the only system through which taxpayer numbers may be issued; its own operating instruction publishes the boundary of the digital route, listing fourteen taxes and contributions that

still require a prior declaration. Customs launched ASYCUDAWorld on 26 January 2026, replacing ASYCUDA++, in use since the early 1990s, across all computerised customs offices, among them the Port of Bissau, the international airport, São Domingos, Gabú and Bafatá, with UNCTAD providing the technical assistance and the African Development Bank the money. Company registration runs through a one-stop shop, the Centro de Formalização de Empresas, which brings together the notary, commercial registration, taxpayer registration and business licensing, and the Judiciary Police runs an online complaint portal.

All of it operates without a horizontal law: the Electronic Transactions Law was still a draft out to public consultation by the regulator in May 2026, so the customs, tax, wage-bill and Treasury systems already in use have no statute giving electronic filings and electronic payments to the state their legal effect. Openness has gone backwards on the same stretch: parliament's Dados Abertos page, which serves four datasets over an API, carries a stated last-modification date of 1 April 2015.

The system's steering committee heard in April 2023 that the other forces had sent no staff, the Judicial Police citing a 2011 law as its basis. A second service opened at the Guarda Nacional command in Bissau in August 2024, linking the police forces' criminal data.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Bissau city council launched CMB+ on 22 September 2026, a modernisation and digital transformation project that incorporates a municipal portal for residents' access to council services, with no budget or timetable published, and a one-stop digitalised transport licensing counter opened at Gabú in March 2026, the first integrated service counter outside the capital. Otherwise the government's systems are national ones: SIGFIP for public financial management and Kontaktu for tax run at national level (2025). A management information system being built with a sub-national footprint is the PESIDE project's education data system, implemented at central and regional level with equipment for the Regional Directorates of Education (2025).

Rural digital data capture

Where a record is made outside Bissau, it is made on paper. Health data relies on manual, error-prone entry across more than twenty fragmented systems (2024), and civil registration had only begun moving onto the digital SIREC system, with birth registration below half of children under five (2025). What has been computerised is concentrated: the criminal information system was inaugurated at the national headquarters of the Polícia Judiciária (March 2023), justice-sector systems are the ministry's own, with a prisoners' database and the Judiciary Police's forum website beside them (2023), and customs computerisation runs at the port, the airport and the offices of São Domingos, Gabú and Bafatá (January 2026).

Digital capture that does reach rural places arrives with a visiting team rather than with a local institution. A vehicle for mobile civil registration in remote areas was handed to the civil registry directorate at SIREC's launch (January 2025) and registry officers were trained on its enrolment kits (2025); mobile justice and civil registration services reached remote communities during 2025, and a registry officer on one mission called for identity cards to be issued on the islands themselves; and a nationwide mapping of schools financed by a GPE-backed project built a database of schools, teachers and students for every region (February 2026). The physical conditions for anything standing are thin: electricity access outside Bissau ran under 5% in 2023, and there is no national backbone linking the main cities, with international connectivity confined to the coast (2025).

The governance record around it is deteriorating faster than any other part of the country's. The Rural Economy fell 22.4 points over 2014-2023 to 26.0 of 100 in 2023, 43rd of 54 and the largest decline of any of the index's 16 sub-categories; within it, rural land and water access fell 49.0 points to 25.9 of 100 in 2023, the largest ten-year fall of any of the country's 96 indicators, and rural representation and participation fell 13.3 points to 24.5 of 100.

Technology

AI

Guinea-Bissau's government has stated a direction on artificial intelligence before running any of it: the Ministry of Public Health told the WHO global conference on AI for health in Lisbon on 14 July 2026 that the country is at an initial stage of AI adoption in health and is building the basis for responsible implementation, with digital transformation named a strategic priority for the health system and for universal health coverage.

Government operations carry nothing that answers to it. The blockchain wage-bill and pensions platform, the most advanced administrative system on the country's record, was not integrated with any AI model as of October 2024, though the IMF frames the payment data it generates as training material for future models able to flag wrongful or misdirected payments. The World Bank's Digital Economy Diagnostic characterises the digital sector as embryonic (2022).

The instrument most likely to reach the country first is regional rather than national: the ECOWAS digital roadmap of January 2026 commits the bloc to a regional AI governance framework for West Africa. Domestically the AI activity on record is training rather than deployment — an AI-themed competition for 35 young people in four teams, with three months of mentoring, backed by the World Bank-financed WARDIP project (August 2026).

ICT Industry

Guinea-Bissau ranks last in Africa for economic diversification, 54th of 54, scoring 16.2 of 100 in 2023 after a fall of 2.1 points over the decade to 2023 — the footing on which any technology industry would have to be built, and it has been narrowing rather than widening.

What industry exists is telecommunications, and it is concentrated. The regulator ARN finds both operators to hold significant market power and warns that Telecel's residual share of investment could seriously compromise competition (June 2025), with Orange Bissau accounting for the large majority of subscribers, sector turnover and capital spending in the same quarter. Outside telecoms the pattern is a market that has not formed at all: no private-sector provider of meteorological observations or data services operates in the country, leaving the state service as the whole of supply (July 2024), and electronic verification against the national ID is offered by commercial eKYC vendors matching a document photo against a selfie.

The institutional scaffolding is thin in the same direction. The national standards body, DSNPQ, is a directorate of service inside the Ministry of Commerce, Industry, Tourism and Handicrafts rather than an autonomous standards institute, and the WTO Secretariat found the expansion of foreign trade hindered by the lack of operational quality control mechanisms and a weak industrial fabric (2017). The state's own supply-side move is planned rather than built: the national digital transformation strategy provides for a phased Centro Nacional de Dados to consolidate the small processing centres scattered across ministries and to serve as a test-bed for private-sector projects, with its viability made conditional on reliable electricity that the strategy places outside its own scope.

The commercial technology sector is correspondingly small: a 2026 survey put the fintech population at an estimated 5 to 15 firms and found no standalone national fintech strategy.

Innovation ecosystem

Guinea-Bissau's innovation infrastructure was assembled by donors rather than by the state. Kau Criar, the country's innovation hub, came out of Hack4SDGs and UNDP's PALOP Innovation Journey from 2020 with InnovaLab and the World Bank, took shape in 2021 under UNDP's economic resilience work, and was steered by a taskforce of AIGB, InnovaLab, CIDE, Impact Hub Bissau, the UNDP Youth Sounding Board and Youth Conekt (2023). The hub occupies the former DECOMEL building in Bissau, chosen over three other sites, and offers hot desks, meeting rooms and capacity building under Impact Hub Bissau's temporary management.

Beside the hub, InnovaLab, a think tank offering investment, incubation, acceleration, capacity building and consultancy, has worked in Guinea-Bissau for more than ten years (2026).

Acceleration has run on a Lusophone circuit. UNDP's five-country PALOP E-voluir journey, with Fábrica de Startups Brasil as technical partner and Djassi Africa as strategic partner, carried three ventures — Djemberém, a business incubator; Ebantaba de Conhecimento, in e-education; and ABIPTOM, a digital information platform for farmers — towards an MVP pitch to jurors on 27-28 May 2021, to be followed by ten further weeks of acceleration and a pitch to prospective investors. That routing through the other Portuguese-speaking states and a Brazilian partner is deliberate: the initiative is built to strengthen a Lusophone network of innovation and entrepreneurship.

The innovation with the widest reach sits inside government rather than in this sector: the IMF describes the wage-bill platform as an early use of blockchain to improve government operations in sub-Saharan Africa (October 2024).

Two newer programmes run beside the hub: a digital-economy entrepreneurship fund backed by the WARDIP programme selected its first cohort of 30 projects in March 2026, and an operator's digital centre launched a structured incubation and acceleration programme in April 2026.

Capacity

Literacy

Guinea-Bissau's primary teachers do not master what they teach: set the same tests as their pupils, 32% could not answer the Year 2 Portuguese paper correctly and 54% the mathematics paper, and by Year 5, 95% did not master the Portuguese they teach and 98% the mathematics (2017). Pupils sit under that ceiling — Year 2 pupils master less than half of what the programme requires and Year 5 pupils about a third — and results vary by a factor of up to thirty depending on which school a child attends (2017). Secondary education has no uniform curriculum, and the ministry's own sector plan calls that absence a graver problem than the level's high drop-out (2017).

The measures that have moved since have moved apart: completion rose 17.2 points over 2014-2023 to 30.8 of 100, while quality fell 16.6 points to 16.7 of 100, 47th of 54, at once among the ten worst-scoring and the ten most deteriorated (2023). Upper-secondary completion was 11.7% for girls against 15.8% for boys (2022), education took 10.4% of the effective budget against a 20% target (2023).

Digital literacy is now one of the ten pillars of the Estratégia Nacional para a Transformação Digital, adopted by Decreto n.º 10/2025 in March 2025, whose objective OE5 commits the state to raising the population's digital literacy and to training the specialised technical staff the public sector will increasingly need. Its interventions promise a compulsory introductory ICT subject in every secondary and higher-education course, computer-literacy content for schools and adult training, repeating campaigns on secure and responsible online behaviour and free public wifi squares as an instrument of literacy rather than of connectivity alone. They start from a civil service the World Bank judged low in digital skills (2023). Several hundred girls were enrolled in a digital-literacy programme (2025).

The digital-literacy half of OE5 comprises six numbered interventions with scheduled windows running from July 2025 to December 2029; what has been delivered against them so far was financed and run by a donor, not by the ministry that owns them.

Training and skills

The one measured baseline of digital skills in Guinea-Bissau's public service found that 92% of the justice-sector staff surveyed had never received any digital training in their workplace (March 2023). The outcome reported for the training that followed was self-reported: an improvement in staff's perception of their own digital skills and of work-process efficiency (2023). Digital skills in the civil service and political bodies were low, and the government's stated commitment to digital skills had seen little done (2023); the digital strategy's commitment to train specialised technical staff for the public sector postdates that assessment.

What training is on the record is attached to individual projects. 365 customs officers, licensed customs agents, shipping agents and other stakeholders were trained over five months for the ASYCUDAWorld rollout (January 2026); 63 civil registry officials were trained on digital registration systems (2025); a committee set up by joint decree in May 2026 supervises an operator-government programme to train 1,000 young people a year for four years in programming, data analysis and cloud computing; the regulator ARN entered WATRA's Sida-backed SPIDER training programme and sent five technicians on a benchmarking mission to the Nigerian Communications Commission (2021). The most recent is an AI-themed competition for a few dozen young people, backed through the third Orange Summer Challenge by the World Bank-financed WARDIP project with three months of mentoring (August 2026).

Two findings bound what any of it can reach. Teacher subject competence sits below the level being taught (2017), so training builds on schooling that did not deliver the basics; and educational attainment does not convert into work — the ILO finds NEET rates do not fall uniformly as attainment rises, and that young adults with upper-secondary education are at least as likely, if not more likely, to be NEET than those with only basic education (2022).

Research institutions

A private, Lusophone route into computer engineering runs in Guinea-Bissau: Universidade Lusófona da Guiné-Bissau runs a Licenciatura em Engenharia Informática of eight semesters, accredited by the Ministry of Education under Decreto-Lei n.º 1/2008.

Inclusion

Access to services

The reach of Guinea-Bissau's cash transfer programmes collapsed inside a single year, from around 66,000 people, 7.6 per cent of the population in poverty, in 2021 to under 7,000 people, or 0.7 per cent, in 2022. Nothing underneath holds the count steady: a National Social Registry is still being established, under a World Bank project approved in January 2025.

Exclusion begins before any digital channel opens. Close to 43 per cent of Bissau-Guineans remained outside the formal financial system (2021), and access to banking services is one of the country's worst-scoring governance indicators (2023). Informal employment accounts for over 90 per cent of the active workforce (2023), so the formal registers on which digital public services depend describe a small minority of the population before any question of connectivity arises.

Equal access to public services scored 30.9 of 100 in 2023, 35th of 54 and 1.5 points below its 2014 level — a measure of how far reaching a state service still depends on who a citizen is and where they live.

The strategy adopted in March 2025 answers this on paper. ENTD.GW's Intervenção 13 provides for operational norms safeguarding full access to digital public services for people with special needs, scheduled for January to September 2025, alongside a Portal do Cidadão as a single point of entry to state services. The country is bound by the disability convention's obligations on access to information and communications but has not accepted the inquiry procedure by which a failure of them could be examined.

One population is addressed by name. Decreto n.º 7/2018 records the refugees it covers as 98 per cent Senegalese from Casamance, many of them resident in Guinea-Bissau for more than twenty-five years, and the decree definitively approves their local integration as naturalised citizens.

Digital divides

The regulator's own field measurement in the Bijagós archipelago and Bolama over 5-7 May 2023 found no mobile signal in 18.6% of MTN's readings and 26.2% of Orange's, and in the same campaign over a third of attempted calls failed or dropped and about half of data tests could not complete. That is what a national coverage percentage leaves out, on a network with no national backbone linking the main cities (2025) and with electricity concentrated almost entirely in the capital (2023).

The divide between people is moving in the opposite direction to the headline. The youth NEET rate — 15-29 year olds not in employment, education or training — was 17.0 per cent in 2022, significantly down on 2019, while over the same period the gaps between young people with and without disabilities widened, young men with disabilities being out of employment, education or training at around double the rate of those without in 2022. The aggregate improved and the excluded group did not.

The state's answer to the cost side of the divide is written but unpriced: ENTD.GW's Intervenção 15 commits the country to free citizen access to every digital public service on the gov.gw domain between July 2025 and March 2026, with the cost either negotiated with the telecom operators as consideration for their licences or borne by the Universal Access Fund. The reach that would have to be closed is wider than the price of a megabyte. More than three in five workers are in agriculture (2022), which is the labour market any digital-skills programme is placing its graduates into, and the ILO finds educational attainment does not convert into work — young adults with upper-secondary education are at least as likely to be NEET as those with only basic schooling.

Data

National statistics

Guinea-Bissau counted itself digitally for the first time in 2026: the fourth population and housing census went to the field in June, and its preliminary results, released on 23 July 2026, put the population at 2,191,202. The capacity of Guinea-Bissau's statistical system scored 21.3 of 100 in 2023, 52nd of 54 countries, in an index that has no data for Guinea-Bissau on 18 of its 96 indicators. Data sources is the weakest of the five pillars of the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators, under 20 per cent in 2023. In the twenty years to 2023 the country held a population census but neither an agricultural census nor a business or establishment census, and in the ten years to 2023 no agricultural or business survey either.

Coordination has failed twice over. The Conselho Nacional de Informação Estatística, created in 1991, never functioned — a failure the 2007 framework law names in its own preamble as one of the conditions it was enacted against — and that same preamble identifies excessive functional decentralisation, with no coordinating function across the system and a proliferation of ministerial statistical services. Eleven years on, the successor body, the Conselho Superior da Estatística, was itself recorded as non-functional in 2018.

Guinea-Bissau's first statistics development strategy, ENDE-1 (2015–2017), executed at 24.13 per cent, its successor attributing the shortfall to a human-resources deficit, insufficient state financing and political instability. That successor, validated in October 2018, programmed both a population and housing census and an agriculture and livestock census for 2019 and made its first operational objective the promulgation of a statistics decree-law approved in Council of Ministers in September 2017 and still unpromulgated a year later.

Outside education, fisheries, health and agriculture, sectoral statistical production is "practically non-existent". The education ministry's last official statistical yearbook covers the 2014–2015 school year, with only partial data released since. The telecoms regulator computes the penetration rates in its 2025 market observatory against a World Bank 2021 population figure projected forward at 2.2 per cent a year. The WTO Secretariat records that its economic performance indicators are no more than estimates, given collection weaknesses and an informal sector put at 70 per cent of the economy on the authorities' own figure. INE has since published a vital-statistics yearbook covering 2018–2022.

Open data

What the state publishes and what a citizen can obtain have moved in opposite directions. Disclosure of public records — what government puts out of its own accord — rose 12.5 points over 2014–2023 to 25.0 of 100, 38th of 54, while accessibility of public records, whether citizens can actually obtain government records and data, fell 6.0 points to 6.7 of 100 in 2023, 50th of 54, one of the country's ten worst and ten most deteriorated indicators. Guinea-Bissau has no access-to-information law in force (October 2024).

The one recent addition is macroeconomic. Guinea-Bissau implemented the IMF's enhanced General Data Dissemination System and launched its National Summary Data Page on 8 July 2024, publishing national accounts and prices, government operations and debt, the monetary and financial sector and the external sector in both human-readable and machine-readable form at launch, with data supplied by INE, the Ministry of Finance and the regional central bank BCEAO. The page is hosted on a national Open Data Platform provided by the African Development Bank, and participation in the standard is voluntary.

The other national open-data facility belongs to parliament. The Assembleia Nacional Popular runs a Dados Abertos page exposing four JSON datasets over an API — institutional, ombudsman, legislative-process and transparency data — alongside an endpoint serving all published site content in the same machine-readable format, built on Interlegis and taking its definition of open data from Brazil's federal open-data portal and the Open Knowledge Foundation. The page carries a stated last-modification date of 1 April 2015.

Only three categories clear the midpoint of the 2024 Open Data Inventory: government finance at 7.0 out of 10, balance of payments at 6.5 and price statistics at 5.5. Education and health facilities, at 1.5 and 2.5, are the country's two lowest assessed categories.

Use of satellite data

Guinea-Bissau's national meteorological institute operates no automatic weather stations at all, and very few of its meteorological, climatological and agrometeorological stations are in fully operational mode, on a peer review conducted in July 2024. The same assessment rates the Instituto Nacional de Meteorologia level 1 overall — the bottom of the Country Hydromet Diagnostics scale — with only four of its elements reaching level 2, and finds technical infrastructure not adapted to digitalisation. There are no private-sector providers of meteorological observations or data services in the country, leaving the state service as the whole of the supply. INM-GB is a semi-autonomous body under the Ministry of Transport, Communications and Digital Economy, the ministry that also holds the digital portfolio, and the country has been a member of the World Meteorological Organization since 13 January 1978.

Where ground observation is thin, the operational earth-observation product for Guinea-Bissau is foreign-run. FAO's Global Information and Early Warning System publishes satellite-derived agricultural monitoring indicators for the country, built from METOP and ECMWF inputs and mapped over the latest 36-month period — three seasonal indicators, the Agricultural Stress Index, Drought Intensity and the Weighted Mean Vegetation Health Index, for two crop seasons, and five non-seasonal ones including NDVI anomaly, vegetation and health condition indices and estimated precipitation, all over cropland and grassland masks.

The limit on that substitution is in the data it is built on. FAO states that its seasonal indicators may diverge from local conditions because of limits in the crop phenology and crop mask data, in a country that has run no agricultural census in the twenty years to 2023. The same pattern holds in health, where the climate-health tooling drawing temperature, humidity, heat-stress and precipitation data from global datasets sits on a DHIS2 testing instance rather than in national production (July 2026).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Starlink began commercial service in Guinea-Bissau on 19 June 2025, its seventh West African and twentieth continental market, with hardware at about XOF 228,000 (roughly $400) and service at about $63 a month at launch.

The regulator had cleared the way two months earlier, when ARN-TIC granted Starlink Guinea-Bissau a general provisional authorisation on 10 April 2025, following a provisional licence issued in December 2024, and extended it on 14 September 2026 to the end of the year.

China activities

The regional body Guinea-Bissau belongs to now works from a Chinese-built seat: the China-aid ECOWAS Headquarters Building was handed over in Abuja on 28 April 2026, presented by Beijing as an outcome under the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation.

EU activities

European money runs the civil systems Guinea-Bissau's administration has actually digitised, without digital being one of the EU's stated priorities for the country: the civil registration system launched at the first conservatória in Bissau in January 2025 was financed by the European Union, built with Portuguese public bodies and the Universidade de Aveiro under the GESTDOC project, and the education ministry's statistical platform is being equipped, trained and technically advised through PESIDE, a project running to November 2026, financed by the European Union.

The programme that governs that spending sets human development, a green and inclusive economy, and good governance and stability as its three priority areas, with digital named nowhere among them, and the same document records that joint programming among development partners had not been achieved in the country.

At the regional level the EU is scoping the trust layer a single West African digital market would need: the ECOWAS certified electronic signature workshop was convened with the EU Digital for Development Hub, framed by the EU delegation under the Global Gateway strategy and the EUR 150 billion investment package agreed at the February 2022 EU-AU Summit, and named a first step towards a harmonised regional digital environment.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf or Emirati involvement in Guinea-Bissau's digital sector had been recorded as at September 2026.

India activities

No Indian state or commercial involvement in Guinea-Bissau's digital sector had been recorded as at September 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Guinea-Bissau has begun building a home for state data of its own: construction of a National Data Center was launched in 2025, where the World Bank had found no government data centre and no shared services in 2022. The prime minister said the building for ITMA, the administration's modernisation agency, financed by Japan with EUR 1.93 million through UNDP, would house the country's data centre (March 2024).

No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026. A draft data governance policy was approved in Council of Ministers in July 2025, and the WARDIP-financed interoperability framework of July 2024 names data sovereignty, residence and localisation among its principles and sets avoiding dependence on suppliers among its aims.

The core systems were built by others. Semlex has supplied the national system for managing and issuing biometric identity cards since 2006 and financed the national production centre in Bissau (2021); whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the identity card system, or can exit its contract with Semlex, was not on record as at September 2026. The wage-bill blockchain platform was designed over four years with the IMF and Ernst & Young as technological advisor.

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